strong centralized authority dominated by a heavy police and military presence.

CONCLUSION

The international community may be reaching a crossroads in dealing with the military regime in Myanmar. For the past two decades, Western nations have attempted to isolate the regime and possibly institute regime change. These policies have failed miserably. The peasants in Myanmar bore the brunt of the suffering because of the sanctions, trade restrictions, and investment limitations imposed by international actors. With a military option totally out of the question, international policy in dealing with Myanmar is problematic. With no chance of China, India, or the Southeast Asian community taking a hard-line stance against the junta, serious progress seemed unrealistic. However, the positive moves made recently seem irreversible.

One option is to continue the constructive engagement in the hope of enticing reform in Myanmar. The United Nations appointed Ibrahim Gambari to try and facilitate dialogue with the junta. An international consensus must be structured in order to pressure the regime at the appropriate time. Simultaneously, global actors must provide serious incentives to prod the junta to continue the reforms already underway. Only a solid plan to do both can work if change is going to occur. Only time will tell if Aung San Suu Kyi and Thein Sein can successful manage the process that is currently underway. Factions within both the military and democratic opposition are not totally content with the steps that have been taken. Whether these steps are irreversible remains to be seen.